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THEATRE ARTS

SET DESIGN

Set Design: Reading the Script for Space

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

How a designer turns a script into requirements: entrances, levels, sightlines, budget and the one image the whole design will be built from.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- script analysis
- requirements list
- the controlling image
- sightlines
- budget

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Read for what the play needs, not what it mentions

List every entrance and exit with the page number, every object that is used, every level an actor must reach and every time the location changes. Then add what the play needs but does not mention: somewhere for two people to be alone, a way for one character to overhear another, a door that can be locked.

A design that satisfies the script is not yet a design, but a design that fails the script is a set of furniture. Do the list before you draw anything.

The controlling image

Every good set can be described in one sentence and remembered in one image: a room with too many doors, a house that is also a cage, a wall that moves closer. Find the image in the play's argument, not in its stage directions. Then test every later decision against it: if the image is "a house being sold", the chairs should look packed, not merely old.

The ground plan is the real design

The ground plan decides the acting. Draw it at 1:25 on paper large enough to think on, and walk the routes: from the door to the table, from the window to the stairs, from wherever the actor enters to wherever they must be in eight lines. Actors cannot cross a wall; if the plan makes them walk around furniture to reach each other, the scene will lose its energy.

Mark the sightlines from the worst seats in the house: the extreme side seats of the front row and the back row of the gallery. Anything inside the shaded area is invisible and should hold nothing the audience needs to see.

Building what you can afford

A departmental budget buys paint, timber and fabric, not scenery. Design within it: two well-built flats and a rostra, painted and lit properly, will look better than six badly built walls. Decide early what is real (a table an actor can stand on), what is suggested (a window frame with a cloth behind it) and what is painted (a skyline on a cyclorama).

Talk to the workshop before the design is fixed. The carpenter, the painter and the stage manager will tell you which idea costs three days and which costs an afternoon, and the design is better for knowing.

Presenting the design

A design is presented three times: to the director, to the company, and to the workshop. Each needs a different document. The director needs the idea and the ground plan; the company needs to see where they enter and what they can stand on; the workshop needs dimensions, materials and a date.

Make one presentation sheet: the model photographed from the audience, the ground plan, a materials board with the actual paint colours and fabric swatches, and three sentences of intention. Pin it up in the rehearsal room for the whole rehearsal period. Actors work better in a space they can imagine, and a design that lives only in the designer's folder is discovered, not rehearsed.

Be ready to cut. A design that cannot be built in the time available is not ambitious, it is late. Decide in advance which element is the idea and which are the trimmings, so that when the schedule slips, you cut a trimming and

keep the idea.

Three questions before you draw

Where does the audience sit, and what can they see? What must the stage do physically - how many doors, how much floor, how high? And what is the one thing the audience must understand about this world before anyone speaks? Answer those three and the design has a brief; skip them and it has a style.

Keep the brief to one page and pin it above the drawing board. Every decision afterwards can be tested against it, and when the director asks for a change you can say what the change costs in the terms of the brief rather than in taste.

Exercises

1. Make the requirements list for a one-act play: entrances, objects, levels, locations, with page numbers.
2. Draw a 1:25 ground plan for that play on a 6 m by 4 m stage, with sightlines marked.
3. Write a build list with quantities and an estimated cost in naira for the plan you drew.

Where to read more

Howard Bay, Stage Design (1974)

Darwin Reid Payne, Theory and Craft of the Scenic Model (1975)

J. Michael Gillette, Theatrical Design and Production (2012)

These are books to look for in a library or a bookshop. They are not on this shelf and ZikShare does not host them.